Chapter 1

The morning was cold and the road was empty. Corin Cadence walked toward the tower with a notebook under his arm and no plan at all.

He had been told that the tower was dangerous, that the tests were unfair, and that nobody would help him inside. He had decided to go anyway.

At the gate a guard looked at his papers, sighed, and waved him through. The corridor beyond smelled of dust and old paper.

Chapter 2

Inside, the tower was quieter than he expected. Every step echoed twice, as if the walls were repeating his decisions back at him.

A woman in a grey coat waited by the stairs. She did not introduce herself. She only said that the first test had already begun and that he had failed it twice.

Corin wrote that down. It seemed like the kind of thing that would matter later.

Chapter 3

The last room had no door. There was a window, a chair, and a clock that ran backwards. On the chair lay a book with his name on the cover.

He opened it and found that the pages were blank except for one sentence: the story begins when the reader stops waiting for permission.

He closed the book, put it in his bag, and climbed back down the stairs.